Energized by the winds of change, in 1991, Tata Tea looked for opportunities to expand internationally. It formed a JV in Sri Lanka called Estate Management Services (Pvt.) Ltd to manage eighteen tea and rubber estates that were privatized by the government. It also forged an agreement to establish a JV with the State Trading Organization of Iran to assist in the upgradation of their tea manufacturing base, modernization of the processing facilities, setting up of a packaging plant and to jointly market its brands in the country. Simultaneously, it 'set up a pilot plant at Munnar [in Kerala] for the production of button mushrooms'. Besides, it forayed into the business of brands and acquired a 52.5 per cent stake in Consolidated Coffee Limited, now known as Tata Coffee Limited.

The following year, in a 'major move to stabilise and boost the export of Indian tea and other agro products', it entered into an equal-stake JV agreement with a Russian firm, Krasnodar Tea Company. In addition, it announced plans to establish a wholly owned subsidiary, Tata Tea International Limited, in Jersey, Channel Islands, UK and to invest in more JVs in Sri Lanka.

In the same year, the company also set up an export JV with Lyons Tetley of UK to create Tata Tetley, to export manufactured teabags to the Middle Eastern and east European markets. The new venture was encouraged by Tetley's appreciation of the quality of tea that it was buying from the Indian company from the Florida-based Tata Tea Inc. (a wholly owned Tata subsidiary established in 1984).

Ratan in the Saddle

In 1995, Ratan said that with the 'considerable increase in competition', there was a need for the company to 'transform itself' from 'being a manufacturer of a commodity' into a 'consumer products manufacturing company'. He underlined the need to emphasize the 'packaging of its brands', enhance the 'equity of its brands' and strengthen distribution. He added that Tata Tea 'was fully geared to change its approach to deal with the challenges ahead and emerge as a sharply focused marketing company'.

In 1994, the company had attempted to acquire Tetley, the largest beverage manufacturer in the UK and the second largest in the US, owned by Allied Domecq, the world's second-largest wine and spirits company. It turned out to be a futile endeavour. But that did not dampen Ratan's spirit;